



Meaninglessness of Suffering -

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Ecclesiastes 3:16–4:3

¹⁶ Moreover, I saw under the sun that in the place of justice, even there was wickedness, and in the place of righteousness, even there was wickedness. ¹⁷ I said in my heart, God will judge the righteous and the wicked, for there is a time for every matter and for every work. ¹⁸ I said in my heart with regard to the children of man that God is testing them that they may see that they themselves are but beasts.

¹⁹ For what happens to the children of man and what happens to the beasts is the same; as one dies, so dies the other. They all have the same breath, and man has no advantage over the beasts, for all is vanity. ²⁰ All go to one place. All are from the dust, and to dust all return. ²¹ Who knows whether the spirit of man goes upward and the spirit of the beast goes down into the earth? ²² So I saw that there is nothing better than that a man should rejoice in his work, for that is his lot. Who can bring him to see what will be after him?

⁴ Again I saw all the oppressions that are done under the sun. And behold, the tears of the oppressed, and they had no one to comfort them! On the side of their oppressors there was power, and there was no one to comfort them. ² And I thought the dead who are already dead more fortunate than the living who are still alive.

³ But better than both is he who has not yet been and has not seen the evil deeds that are done under the sun.

Does suffering have any meaning?

When we suffer we Question: Justice, Wisdom and Hope.

1. We Question the Justice of God.

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2. We Question the plan of God.

Ecclesiastes 3:16–4:3

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“God whispers to us in our pleasures, speaks in our conscience, but shouts in our pains; it is his megaphone to rouse a deaf world”. “Pain,” Lewis continues, “shatters the creature’s false self-sufficiency; the will must be surrendered to God”

“What grounds has [Joy’s death] given me for doubting all that I believe? ...We were even promised sufferings. They were part of the program. We were told, ‘Blessed are they that mourn,’ and I accepted it. I’ve got nothing that I hadn’t bargained for. Of course it is different when the thing happens to oneself, not to others, and in reality, not in the imagination”.

3. We Question the hope we have in God.

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“We can have no power from Christ unless we live in a persuasion that we have none of our own.”

Isaiah 40:1-5

Comfort, comfort my people, says your God.

2 Speak tenderly to Jerusalem,
and cry to her
that her warfare is ended,
that her iniquity is pardoned,
that she has received from the Lord's hand
double for all her sins.

3 A voice cries:

“In the wilderness prepare the way of the Lord;
make straight in the desert a highway for our God.

4 Every valley shall be lifted up,
and every mountain and hill be made low;
the uneven ground shall become level,
and the rough places a plain.

5 And the glory of the Lord shall be revealed,
and all flesh shall see it together,
for the mouth of the Lord has spoken.”

We view pain differently in different stages of life.

1. When you are young you ask in wonder - Can God be good in the midst of my pain

2. When you are older you ask - Where is God in my pain

3. When you are older still you say - God held me even when I let go of him in my pain.

Hebrews 11:10

10 For he was looking **forward** to the city that has foundations, whose designer and builder is God.

Hebrews 11:13-16

13 All these people died still believing (Still walking in a Trembling Trust) what God had promised them. They did not receive what was promised, but they saw it all from a distance and welcomed it. They agreed that they were foreigners and nomads here on earth. 14 Obviously people who say such things are looking forward to a country they can call their own. 15 If they had longed for the country they came from, they could have gone back. 16 But they were looking for a better place, a heavenly homeland. That is why God is not ashamed to be called their God, for he has prepared from them a city.